Four Monstrous Data Breaches in a Couple of Decades

- Anneliese S. Little
- Department of Cybersecurity: Charleston Southern University

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- Dr. Jonathan Sun
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What is Monster.com?

- Employment website used all over the world
- Connects people looking for a job to employers (What is Monster.com, n.d.)
- Look for job openings, upload resumes, apply for positions across industries and locations (What is Monster.com, n.d.)
- Employers post job listings, look for candidates, manage recruitment (What is Monster.com, n.d.)
- Career advice, resume tools, resources for searchers and recruiters (What is Monster.com, n.d.)
- Monster.com has experienced four major breaches

Data Breach of August 2007

- Hackers took 1.6 million files (Phillips, 2007)
- Hackers used a Trojan virus, log-ins and passwords to access information (Phillips 2007)
- Transferred data to site in Eastern Europe, Ukraine (Phillips, 2007)
- Hackers called the virus info stealer monster (Montagne, 2007)
- Surprisingly only small percent of Monster.com users affected (Brand & Dimsdale, 2007)



What Information was Affected?



Names, addresses, phone numbers, and email addresses (Brand & Dimsdale, 2007)



Insisted no bank account information, credit card numbers, or Social Security numbers were leaked (Brand & Dimsdale, 2007)



Thieves trying to get more information (Brand & Dimsdale, 2007)



Used leaked information to send phishing emails posing as Monster.com recruiters trying to get bank account information (Brand & Dimsdale, 2007)

Monster.com's Response

- The attack occurred on August 17th, an investigation and shut down of hacker services occurred the 19th or 20th, Monster.com actually responded 22nd about email scams (Brand & Dimsdale, 2007)
- Told users over a million resumes compromised on 23rd (Brand & Dimsdale, 2007)
- Sent notices via snail mail by using postal delivery because of customer reluctancy (Brand & Dimsdale, 2007)
- Much lower earnings, cut 15% of staff (about 800 layoffs), tried to strengthen security (Brand & Dimsdale, 2007)



Data Breach of October 2007

- Another attack two months later
- iFrame, via a toolkit, attack that redirected users to affected parts of website (Claburn, 2009)

Problems Attack Caused

- Portions of website compromised (Goodin, 2007)
- Hijacked job listings (Goodin, 2007)
- Malware spread to users (Goodin, 2007)
- Though most Windows systems were able to mitigate it with anti-virus programs (Goodin, 2007)

How Monster Fixed the Situation

Took compromised pages down, scrubbed them, and put them back up (Goodin, 2007)

Another Data Breach in 2009



Attackers broke into databases (Claburn, 2009)



Similar warning posted on USAJobs.gov, depends on Monster for provider (Claburn, 2009)



Unsure who the hackers were or where they came from

Client Information Stolen

- Contact and account data (Claburn, 2009)
- User IDs (Claburn, 2009)
- Passwords (Claburn, 2009)
- Email addresses (Claburn, 2009)
- Names (Claburn, 2009)
- Phone numbers (Claburn, 2009)

- Demographic data (Claburn, 2009)
- Date of birth (Claburn, 2009)
- Gender (Claburn, 2009)
- Ethnicity (Claburn, 2009)
- State of residence in some cases (Claburn, 2009)

What Monster.com did

- Declined to admit number of affected users (Claburn, 2009)
- Every user may have been (Claburn, 2009)
- Notify via website instead of email (Claburn, 2009)
- Claimed users in Europe were not affected (Claburn, 2009)
- Suggested to change passwords (Claburn, 2009)

Yet Another Breach 10 Years Later

- Sensitive information found on unsecured web server from third party (Whittaker, 2019)
- Most users located in U.S. (Whittaker, 2019)
- Compromised information no longer on that site, but still circulating (Whittaker, 2019)

What was Leaked

Thousands of resumes and CVs (curriculum vitae) from 2014 to 2017

(Whittaker, 2019)

Not all from Monster, but several were

(Whittaker, 2019)

Phone numbers, home addresses, email addresses, and prior work experience

(Whittaker, 2019)

Monster’s Lack of Accountability

Fault of one of the customers (Muncaster, 2019)
Should not be held responsible (Muncaster, 2019)
Declined to reveal recruitment customer (Whittaker, 2019)
Did not warn users, only admitted data was exposed (Whittaker, 2019)
Did not identify or confirm affected users (Whittaker, 2019)

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